

Cod.^A to ^B, and urges great caution in the use of ^L. The caution is wise, and yet some of the most important aids to the correction of the text are hidden in that version.

§ 7. THE SEMITIC TEXT.

In places the text of Ezr.-Ne. is very well preserved. In N. especially there is as a rule very little trouble once the interpolations are recognised. But on the whole MT. is in decidedly bad shape. At times the confusion is so great that the work of the critic is most difficult. In some places there is a wholesale corruption of the text in the interest of the historical theory of the editor.

The great majority of writers have accepted MT. and have simply tried to make out of it the best they could. There is no reason, however, for confining ourselves to one text in a case in which we have good support for another and a better reading. In places the result is most surprising and important. Many of the critical theories of both the older and newer writers are dependent on the corrupt MT. A reconstruction of these theories is only possible in the light of a thorough-going criticism of the text. This needs to go much further than Guthe's in Haupt's *SBOT*. I myself worked for years on the supposition that there was an early and fruitless effort to rebuild the temple. But the discovery of the true text of Ezr. 3 compelled a radical change of opinion.

The discovery of these corruptions, and in many places the recovery of the true text, has another important consequence. It proves beyond a doubt that there are original sources where previously a passage has been assigned wholly to Chr. If a text has been corrupted to make it suit a purpose, it is obvious that the text in its original form is not the work of R. In that way it is demonstrated that there are Hebrew sources in these books, and so the contributions of the Chronicler are correspondingly diminished.

§ 8. THE SOURCES.

In the book of Ch. we find many sections of S. and K. inserted almost verbatim. There is a claim further that the compiler used many other sources (see Curt. *Intr.*^{21 ff.}). It is true that some scholars, as Torrey, deny that these sources were genuine, insisting that the Chronicler pretends to quote to add plausibility to his history (ES. c. 7). Our books were originally a part of the book of Ch., and we should expect the same method to have been pursued. And our expectations are realised, for it is possible to pick out some of the sources, even though we have no parallels for control as we have in S. and K. There is not, unfortunately, much agreement among scholars as to the limits of some of these sources. There is nothing then left for me but to give my conclusions, which are, however, based on many years' study of these books. The results will be seen to be decidedly conservative.

(1) *The Memoirs of Nehemiah* = N.

Beginning with a source about the presence of which there is no difference of opinion, there is certainly incorporated in the book which bears his name some personal memoirs of Nehemiah. These are all written in the first person, and the narrative is terse and vivid. The memoirs were written for the most part soon after the close of his first administration (v. 5¹⁴), and as a historical source rank among the very best in OT. Nehemiah knew how to accomplish results, even in the face of the gravest difficulties, and he also knew how to tell what he had done without waste of words. In some places N. has somewhat the character of a diary or journal. The brief prayers and imprecations scattered through the document make the impression of a narrative originally written for the author's eye alone.

The agreement of scholars ceases, however, the moment we attempt to determine the limits of the memoirs. There is a

minimum about which all are agreed, but the moment we step beyond that boundary contention arises.

The vast majority of modern scholars set rather large limits to these memoirs. Berth. Sieg. Ryle, and Dr. practically agree that N. covers Ne. 1-7 12²⁷⁻⁴³ 13⁴⁻³¹. Berth. and Sieg. exc. 12^{27-30. 38-36}, but Sieg. adds 11^{1f.} and Dr. adds 13¹⁻⁴. Torrey, on the other extreme, finds N. only in 1¹⁻²⁷ 2^{9b-20} 4¹⁻⁶¹⁵. All agree that 7⁶⁻⁷² was not written by Neh., but the scholars who include this in N. suppose, wrongly I believe, that it was incorporated in N. by Neh.

It seems certain that 3¹⁻³² is not from N. It has none of the characteristics of that document, but is very like other lists in our books, and it is quite out of place where it stands, interrupting the narrative sadly (v. notes on Ne. 3). I have shown in the notes reasons which are sufficient to reject 2^{7-9a}. I can see no satisfactory evidence against 3³³⁻³⁸ 6¹⁶⁻¹⁹ 7^{1-5a} 13^{6-31a} exc. v. 22. The last passage is not only written in the first p., but also has numerous characteristics of N. On the other hand, I have no hesitation in rejecting 1^{5-11a}, the major portion of Neh.'s prayer, which is too close to a type to be composed by Neh. (v. notes), one point in which I go beyond Torrey, who only goes so far as to assume editorial revision. I believe it a piece of editorial composition. In the passage describing the dedication of the walls (12²⁷⁻⁴³), there are unmistakable traces of N., e. g., in 31 f. 38. 40b, but a story like this was too tempting to the Chr., and he has so embellished it with interpolations to bring pr., Lev., music, and sacrifices into prominent place that Neh.'s own simple, straightforward story is buried beyond hope of recovery. Torrey notes that 2^{19b} 3^{33 ff.} 4^{1 ff.} repeat one another rather awkwardly, an awkwardness much increased by the elimination of 3¹⁻³² (ES.²²⁶). That is quite true, and yet I doubt if any of the passages exc. possibly 3³³⁻³⁵ can be legitimately questioned. The portions which are from N. are, therefore, 1¹⁻⁴ 1^{11b-27} 2^{9b-20} 3^{32-75a} 13⁶⁻³¹.

(2) *The Memoirs of Ezra* = E.

It has been the practically unanimous opinion of Biblical scholars that another important and trustworthy source is found in E. This, it is claimed, includes Ezr. 7²⁷⁻⁸³⁴ 9¹⁻¹⁵; such, at all events, are the conclusion of such competent scholars as Driver, Ryle, Cornill, Kusters, Siegfried, and Bertholet.

Before discussing the matter further, it is necessary to reduce the space of the memoirs somewhat. First, we must eliminate 8¹⁻¹⁴, the